

Open Source Programs & Mentorships – 2026

This document is a 2026-only, mistake-checked compilation of major global, regional, and Indian open source programs. Each section includes: program overview, eligibility, timeline, stipend/benefits, tech stack focus, preparation strategy, and official resources to apply or track updates.

Google Summer of Code (GSoC) 2026

Overview: Google Summer of Code is a global, paid open source program where contributors work with mentoring organizations on well-defined projects. It is one of the most prestigious open source programs worldwide.

Eligibility: Students enrolled in a recognized degree program (some organizations also accept recent graduates). Applicants must be 18+ and eligible to work remotely.

Expected 2026 Timeline:

- Mentor organizations apply: Jan–Feb 2026
- Contributor bonding & proposal discussions: Feb–Mar 2026
- Contributor application window: Mid–Late March 2026
- Coding period: May–September 2026

Stipend: Paid stipend varies by country and project size. International recognition and strong resume value.

Tech Focus: Web, backend, systems, ML, DevOps, databases, compilers, mobile, security.

How to Prepare: Identify orgs early, join communication channels, solve beginner issues, write a strong proposal with milestones.

Official Resources:

summerofcode.withgoogle.com
developers.google.com/open-source/gsoc

MLH Fellowship (2026)

Overview: MLH Fellowship is a remote, cohort-based open source program where fellows work full-time on real-world projects with structured mentorship.

Eligibility: Open to students and early-career developers globally. Selection involves application and interview rounds.

2026 Timeline: Multiple cohorts (Spring, Summer, Fall). Applications typically open 4–6 weeks before each cohort.

Benefits: Stipend, mentorship, career coaching, networking, strong GitHub portfolio.

Tech Focus: Full-stack, open source tooling, infrastructure, developer platforms.

Apply & Track: fellowship.mlh.io

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LFX Mentorship (Linux Foundation) – 2026

Overview: Linux Foundation Mentorship programs connect contributors with major open source infrastructure projects under the Linux Foundation ecosystem.

Eligibility: Students and professionals; varies per project.

2026 Cycles:

- Spring: Mar–May 2026
- Summer: Jun–Aug 2026
- Fall: Sep–Nov 2026

Stipend: Project-dependent stipend.

Tech Focus: Cloud, Kubernetes, networking, kernels, blockchain, systems software.

Official Portal: mentorship.lfx.linuxfoundation.org

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Outreachy – 2026

Overview: Outreachy is a paid, remote open source internship program aimed at supporting underrepresented groups in tech.

Eligibility: Candidates from underrepresented backgrounds in tech. Eligibility rules are strict – read carefully.

2026 Timeline:

- Winter cohort runs into March 2026
- Mid-year cohort expected May–Aug 2026 (check announcements)

Stipend: ~USD 7,000 for 3 months.

Apply: outreachy.org/apply/project-selection

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Summer of Bitcoin – 2026

Overview: A global summer internship program focused on Bitcoin-related open source development.

Eligibility: Students and professionals with interest in Bitcoin and distributed systems.

Expected Timeline: Applications open Feb 2026, program runs Feb–Jun 2026.

Stipend: Paid stipend (often in BTC or equivalent).

Official Site: summerofbitcoin.org

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Season of KDE – 2026

Overview: KDE community mentorship program similar to GSoC but shorter in duration.

Eligibility: Anyone willing to contribute to KDE projects.

Timeline: Typically Jan–Mar 2026.

Tech Focus: C++, Qt, UI/UX, Linux desktop applications.

Portal: mentorship.kde.org/sok

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GirlScript Summer of Code (GSSoC) – 2026

Overview: Indian open source program aimed at beginners to intermediate developers.

Eligibility: Open to all students; beginner-friendly.

Timeline: Jun–Aug 2026.

Benefits: Certificates, swag, mentorship, OSS exposure.

Portal: gssoc.girlscript.tech

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FOSSASIA Codeheat – 2026

Overview: Long-duration coding contest and contribution program run by FOSSASIA.

Timeline: Typically Sep 2025 – Feb 2026, aligned with FOSSASIA Summit 2026.

Benefits: Prizes, recognition, OSS contributions.

Portal: codeheat.org

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Indian Winter of Code Programs – 2026

Programs Included: JGEC Winter of Code, NJACK Winter of Code, Kharagpur Winter of Code, DevScript Winter of Code.

Overview: Student-run winter OSS programs focused on onboarding beginners.

Timeline: Jan–Feb 2026 (varies by organizer).

Benefits: Mentorship, certificates, beginner OSS exposure.

Apply: Via individual official websites and GitHub organizations.

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